

UFC heartbreak continues

Puja Tomar lost to Shauna Bannon in the UFC, **tapping out** after a strong start.

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It was yet another disappointment for Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) fans in India.

Last month, Anshul Jubli suffered a crushing first-round defeat against Quillan Salkild at UFC 312. On March 22, his compatriot Puja Tomar was forced to tap out against Shauna Bannon at UFC Fight Night, compounding the heartbreak for Indian fans.

Expectations had soared as Indian supporters sought redemption after Anshul's devastating knockout, which came just 19 seconds into the fight. **Both Puja and Bannon, newcomers to the promotion, had a point to prove.** The Indian was making only her second UFC appearance, while the Irish fighter had one win and one loss to her name. Statistically, it was an evenly matched contest,

although Bannon had a slight reach advantage of 0.15m. Puja, however, was expected to counter this with her superior ground-and-pound technique.

Yet, the fight followed a familiar script, reminiscent of Anshul's debut against Mike Breeden in 2023. Despite dominating the first two rounds, Anshul had been knocked out due to a lapse in concentration, leaving him vulnerable to Breeden's attack.

Puja started aggressively, keeping Bannon on the defensive. However, the Irish fighter fought back, using her reach effectively to score crucial points towards the end of the opening round.

Midway through the second round, Puja landed a devastating head kick that sent Bannon crashing to the mat. It appeared to be a turning point, as Puja quickly followed up with a flurry of right hooks. Bannon seemed defenceless, but with the referee allowing the fight to continue, she managed to recover, seize Puja's arm, and execute an armbar submission, forcing the Indian to tap out. The officiating came under scrutiny, much like in Anshul's bout against Salkild. **Many felt the fight should have been stopped when Bannon was knocked down, giving Puja a legitimate claim to victory.**

Puja addressed the loss on *Instagram*, writing: "The only real mistake is the one from which we learn nothing. I will come back stronger and very soon." Her comment section was flooded with messages of support and criticism of the officiating.



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